

Transporting Cargo and Materials

To prevent cargo or loose materials from falling or spilling from a car, truck, trailer, etc. onto the road and causing a crash or damage to the roads, drivers must comply with certain state requirements.

A vehicle must be equipped and maintained to prevent loose material from escaping by blowing or spilling and a vehicle bed must:

1. Not have a hole, crack, or other opening through which loose material can escape
2. Be enclosed by side panels and on the front by a panel or the vehicle cab
3. Be enclosed by a securely closed tailgate or panel on the rear to prevent spillage
4. Cover the load securely at the front and back of the load, unless completely enclosed in a compartment or the load does not blow or spill over the load carrying compartment.

No person shall load or transport any loose material on or over the public highways, such as dirt, sand, gravel, wood chips, or other material (except agricultural products in their natural state), capable of blowing or spilling from a vehicle unless:

1. The bed carrying the load is completely enclosed on both sides and on the front and rear by a tailgate, board or panel; and all must be so constructed as to prevent the escape of any part of the load by blowing or spilling; and
2. The top of the load is covered with a canvas, tarpaulin, or other covering firmly secured to the front and back to prevent the escape of the load because of blowing or spilling. This requirement does not apply to:
 - a. Any load-carrying compartment that completely encloses the load; or
 - b. The transporting of any load of loose materials not blowing or spilling over the top of the load-carrying compartment.

Safety Chains

Safety chains are required when certain types of vehicles are towing trailers in order to prevent the trailer from breaking loose and causing a serious crash. A person may not drive a passenger car or light truck while towing a trailer, semi-trailer, or house trailer on a public highway in Texas unless safety chains are attached from a trailer, semi-trailer, or house trailer to the towing vehicle. The types of safety chains and the manner of attachment must be approved by DPS. The requirements of this law do not apply to a passenger car or light truck towing a trailer or semi-trailer used for agricultural purposes or to any trailer or semi-trailer or house trailer operated in compliance with the Federal Motor Carrier Safety Regulations.

Towing

When one vehicle is towing another, the drawbar, chain, rope, cable, or other connection must:

1. Not be longer than 15 feet from one vehicle to another
2. Be strong enough to pull all weight drawn
3. Attach a white flag not less than 12 inches square
4. Not tow more than three vehicles attached to it by mounting the front wheels of trailing vehicles on the bed of another vehicle and leaving only the rear wheels in contact with the roadway

This limit does not apply to trailers transporting poles, pipes, machinery, or other structures that cannot be easily dismembered.

Carbon Monoxide

Beware of carbon monoxide poisoning. Cars produce carbon monoxide, which is a deadly gas. Make sure you are getting plenty of fresh air.

Don't:

1. Leave the motor running in a garage
2. Leave vents open when following closely behind another car
3. Leave the motor running and the windows closed while the car is parked
4. Drive with a defective muffler or exhaust system
5. Use the heater or air conditioner in a parked car with the windows closed in an enclosed space

If you encounter a carbon monoxide poisoning victim, move them to fresh air and call 911.

As a driver, you should know all the safety and operational features of the vehicle you are driving. Make sure you and your passengers are traveling in a vehicle that is safe and in good working order. Drive safely and obey all criminal and traffic laws.